Bias-Free Language

5.251 **Maintaining credibility.** Discussions of bias-free language—language that is neither sexist nor suggestive of other conscious or subconscious prejudices—have a way of descending quickly into politics. But there is a way to avoid the political quagmire: if we focus solely on maintaining credibility with a wide readership, the argument for eliminating bias from our writing becomes much simpler. Biased language that is not central to the meaning of the work distracts many readers and makes the work less credible to them. Few texts warrant a deliberate display of linguistic biases. Nor is it ideal, however, to call attention to a supposed absence of linguistic biases, since this will also distract readers and weaken credibility.

5.252 **Gender bias.** Consider the issue of gender-neutral language. On the one hand, many reasonable readers find it unacceptable to use the generic masculine pronoun (*he* in reference to no one in particular). On the other hand, it is unacceptable to many readers (often different readers) either to resort to nontraditional gimmicks to avoid the generic masculine (by using *he/she* or *s/he*, for example) or to use *they* as a kind of singular pronoun (but see 5.48). Either approach sacrifices credibility with some readers.

5.253 **Other biases.** The same is true of other types of biases, such as slighting allusions or stereotypes based on characteristics such as race, ethnicity, disability, religion, sexual orientation, transgender status, or birth or family status. Careful writers avoid language that reasonable readers might find offensive or distracting—unless the biased language is central to the meaning of the writing.

5.254 **Bias and the editor's responsibility.** A careful editor points out to authors any biased terms or approaches in the work (knowing, of course, that the bias may have been unintentional), suggests alternatives, and ensures that any biased language that is retained is retained by choice. Although some publishers prefer to avoid certain terms or specific usages in all cases, Chicago's editors do not maintain a list of words or usages considered unacceptable. Rather, they adhere to the reasoning presented here and apply it to individual cases. What you should strive for—if you want readers to focus on your ideas and not on the political subtext—is a style that doesn't even hint at the issue. So unless you're involved in a debate about, for example, sexism, you'll probably want a style, on the one hand, that no reasonable person could call sexist and, on the other hand, that never contorts language to be nonsexist.

5.255 **Techniques for achieving gender neutrality.** Achieving gender neutrality for generic references to people often involves rewording. Nine methods are suggested below because no single method will work for every writer or in every context. Choose the combination of methods that works best in the context you've created.

1. Omit the pronoun. Sometimes a personal pronoun is not really necessary. For instance, in *the programmer should update the records when data is transferred to her by the head office*, if there is only one programmer, the pronoun phrase *to her* can be omitted: *the programmer should update the records when data is transferred by the head office*. Note that the shorter sentence is tighter as well as gender-free.
2. Repeat the noun. If a noun and its pronoun are separated by many words, try repeating the noun. For instance, *a writer should be careful not to needlessly antagonize readers, because her credibility would otherwise suffer* becomes *a writer should be careful not to needlessly antagonize readers, because the writer's credibility would otherwise suffer*. Take care not to overuse this technique. Repeating a noun too frequently will irritate readers. If you have to repeat a noun more than twice in a sentence or repeat it too soon, you should probably rewrite the sentence.
3. Use a plural antecedent. By using a plural antecedent, you eliminate the need for a singular pronoun. For instance, *a contestant must conduct himself with dignity at all times* becomes *contestants must conduct themselves with dignity at all times*. The method may cause a slight change in connotation. In the example, a duty becomes a collective responsibility rather than an individual one.
4. Use an article instead of a pronoun. Try replacing the singular personal pronoun with a definite or indefinite article. Quite often you'll find that the effect on the sentence's meaning is negligible. For instance, *A student accused of cheating must actively waive his right to have his guidance counselor present*

becomes *A student accused of cheating must actively waive the right to have a guidance counselor present.*

5. Use the neutral singular pronoun *one*. Try replacing the gender-specific personal pronoun with the gender-neutral singular pronoun *one*. For instance, *an actor in New York is likely to earn more than he is in Paducah* becomes *an actor in New York is likely to earn more than one in Paducah.*
6. Use the relative pronoun *who*. This technique works best when it replaces a personal pronoun that follows *if*. It also requires revising the sentence slightly. For instance, *employers presume that if an applicant can't write well, he won't be a good employee* becomes *employers presume that an applicant who can't write well won't be a good employee.*
7. Use the imperative mood. The imperative eliminates the need for an explicit pronoun. Although its usefulness is limited in some types of writing, you may find that it avoids prolixity and more forcefully addresses the target audience. For instance, *a lifeguard must keep a close watch over children while he is monitoring the pool* becomes *keep a close watch over children while monitoring the pool.*
8. In moderation, use *he or she*. Although it is an easy fix, the phrase *he or she* should be used sparingly, preferably only when no other technique is satisfactory. For instance, *"abstractitis" is Ernest Gowers's term for writing that is so abstract and obtuse (hence abstruse) that the writer does not even know what he is trying to say* becomes *"abstractitis" is Ernest Gowers's term for writing that is so abstract and obtuse (hence abstruse) that the writer does not even know what he or she is trying to say*. If you find you need to repeat the pronouns in the same sentence, don't. Revise the sentence instead.
9. Revise the sentence. If no other technique produces a sentence that reads well, rewrite the sentence so that personal pronouns aren't needed. The amount of revision will vary. For instance, *if a boy or girl misbehaves, his or her privileges will be revoked* might become *if someone misbehaves, that person's privileges will be revoked*. And *a person who decides not to admit he lied will be considered honest until someone exposes his lie* might become *a person who denies lying will be considered honest until the lie is exposed.*

See also 5.256.

5.256 **Gender-neutral singular pronouns.** Traditionally, the only gender-neutral third-person singular personal pronoun in English is *it*, which doesn't refer to humans (with very limited exceptions). Clumsy artifices such as *s/he* and *(wo)man* or artificial genderless pronouns have been tried—for many years—with no success. They won't succeed. And those who use them invite credibility problems. Indefinite pronouns such as *anybody* and *someone* don't always satisfy the need for a gender-neutral alternative because they are traditionally regarded as singular antecedents that call for a third-person singular pronoun. Many people substi-

tute the plural *they* and *their* for the singular *he* or *she*. *They* and *their* have become common in informal usage, but neither is considered fully acceptable in formal writing, though they are steadily gaining ground. For now, unless you are given guidelines to the contrary, be wary of using these forms in a singular sense. This advice, like the techniques for achieving gender neutrality discussed in 5.255, applies mainly to generic references, where the identity of the person is unknown or unimportant. For references to a specific person, the choice of pronoun may depend on the individual. Some people identify not with a gender-specific pronoun but instead with the pronoun *they* and its forms or some other gender-neutral singular pronoun; any such preference should generally be respected. See 5.48.

5.257 **Problematic gender-specific suffixes.** The trend in American English is toward eliminating sex-specific suffixes. Words with feminine suffixes such as *-ess* and *-ette* are easily replaced with the suffix-free forms, which are increasingly accepted as applying to both men and women. For example, *author* and *testator* are preferable to *authoress* and *testatrix*. Compounds with *-man* are more problematic. The word *person* rarely functions well in such a compound; *chairperson* and *anchorperson* sound more pompous and wooden than the simpler (and correct) *chair* or *anchor*. Unless a word is established (such as *salesperson*, which dates from 1901), don't automatically substitute *-person* for *-man*. English has many alternatives that are not necessarily newly coined, including *police officer* (first recorded in 1797), *firefighter* (1903), and *mail carrier* (1788).

5.258 **Necessary gender-specific language.** It isn't always necessary or desirable to use gender-neutral terms and phrasings. If you're writing about something that clearly concerns only one sex (e.g., *women's studies*; *men's golf championship*) or an inherently single-sex institution (e.g., a sorority; a Masonic lodge), trying to use gender-neutral language may lead to absurd prose {be solicitous of a pregnant daughter's comfort; he or she will need your support}.

5.259 **Sex-specific labels as adjectives.** When gender is relevant, it's acceptable to use the noun *woman* as a modifier {woman judge}. In recent decades, *woman* has been rapidly replacing *lady* in such constructions. The adjective *female* is also often used unobjectionably. In isolated contexts it may strike some readers as being dismissive or derogatory (perhaps because it's a biological term used for animals as well as humans), but when parallel references to both sexes are required, the adjectives *male* and *female* are typically the most serviceable choices {the police force has 834 male and 635 female officers}.

5.260 **Avoiding other biased language.** Comments that betray a writer's conscious or unconscious biases or ignorance may cause readers to lose respect for the writer and interpret the writer's words in ways that were never intended. In general, emphasize the person, not a characteristic. A characteristic is a label. It should preferably be used as an adjective, not as a noun. Instead of referring to someone as, for instance, *a Catholic* or *a deaf-mute*, put the person first by writing *a Catholic man* or *he is Catholic*, and *a deaf-and-mute child* or *the child is deaf and mute*. Avoid irrelevant references to personal characteristics such as sex, race, ethnicity, disability, age, religion, sexual orientation, transgender status, or social standing. Such pointless references may affect a reader's perception of you or the person you are writing about or both. They may also invoke a reader's biases and cloud your meaning. When it is important to mention a characteristic because it will help the reader develop a picture of the person you are writing about, use care. For instance, in the sentence *Shirley Chisholm was probably the finest African American woman member of the House of Representatives that New York has ever had*, the phrase *African American woman* may imply to some readers that Chisholm was a great representative "for a woman" but may be surpassed by many or all men, that she stands out only among African American members of Congress, or that it is unusual for a woman or an African American to hold high office. But in *Shirley Chisholm was the first African American woman to be elected to Congress and one of New York's all-time best representatives*, the purpose of the phrase *African American woman* is not likely to be misunderstood.